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WHEN THE GODS GAVE PEOPLE SEX, say the !Kung, they gave us a wonderful thing. Sex is often referred to as food: just as people cannot survive without eating, the !Kung say, hunger for sex can cause people to die. For a population whose food resources are unpredictable and of constant concern, this analogy is significant indeed.

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Talk about sex seems to be of almost equal importance. When women are in the village or out gathering, or when men and women are together, they spend hours recounting details of sexual exploits. Joking about all aspects of sexual experience is commonplace—except between people who maintain “respect” relationships and are forbidden to make sexual references in each other’s presence. Those in “joking” relationships often exchange uproariously funny insults referring to each other’s genitals or sexual behavior: “Your penis is huge!” “Your testicles hang down to your knees and smell!” “Your labia are long, dark, and ugly!” “Screw sand!” “Ejaculate on yourself!” (Most sexual expressions can be employed both in jokes and when serious insults are intended; the context determines how they are received.) Descriptive gestures are likely to accompany insults made in jest. Some exchanges even attract an enthusiastic audience. Onlookers cheer as men pretend to grab each other’s testicles and throw them into the air, to be left hanging in the trees. Lurid details of what vultures or other  266 creatures will do to them become part of the general entertainment.

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